



Sheikh Zayed Mosque

The largest mosque in the United Arab Emirates and the third largest in the world



In 1996, work began on the vast Sheikh Zayed Mosque, the brainchild of the first president of the UAE, Sheikh Zayed bin Sultan Al Nahyan. Construction lasted 11 years and was completed in two stages, in which a reinforced concrete shell was built and then clad in white marble and decoration. The resulting complex measures 430,000 square ft (40,000 square m) and can welcome 55,000 worshippers.

Combining cultures

The mosque's design is a fusion of Moorish, Arabic, and Mughal traditions and reflects the lunar cycle that underpins the Islamic calendar—its white marble changes from cold white to blue as the Moon wanes. More than 30 types of marble—brought from Italy, Macedonia, India, and China—were used in its construction, along with thousands of semiprecious stones, including lapis lazuli, amethyst, onyx, pearl, and aventurine. Floral decoration abounds, notably in the mosaic pavement of the *Sahan* courtyard, which extends over 187,000 square ft (17,400 square m), and on the almost 12,000 columns of the mosque as a whole. The mosque has several record-breaking features—the world's largest hand-knotted carpet, the largest crystal chandelier, and the largest Moroccan dome.



△ MARBLE MASTERPIECE

The mosque dwarfs the buildings that surround it. Its extravagance is reflected in its towering minarets, the multiplicity of its domes and columns, and the huge marble courtyard.